

As an open source community, OpenMRS maintains mailing lists, a blog and other social media groups. It also manages a massive wiki website with extensive documentation on everything from coding conventions to installation guides for newcomers. Potential volunteers are encouraged to contact the core group via mailing lists or post to the OpenMRS Answers resource. They can also talk to the team via its IRC channel, or join a regional community group. JIRA and Crucible are also used to maintain the OpenMRS code-base. This improves the efficiency of the bug-fixing and review process. And it ensures newcomers are not deterred by the inadvertent ignoring of their patches or the failure to provide timely feedback. OpenMRS also encourages long-term volunteers to find paid opportunities by working on OpenMRS implementations. This prevents 'brain drain' from the community and encourages newbies to commit themselves to OpenMRS.

OpenMRS also attracts volunteers through the Google Summer of Code program. I first participated in GSoC back in 2007. Since then, OpenMRS has grown rapidly to become one of the largest mentor organisations to take part in the event. It is also noteworthy that many of the GSoC interns are from developing countries and are in a position to help with any local implementations. Several of them have gone on to find paid opportunities in the OpenMRS core team and other related projects. All these aspects have helped OpenMRS retain talented volunteers for longer.

Looking ahead

The growth of OpenMRS has been both consistent and rapid. Each year has brought with it more and more good news and the past year has certainly been no exception. The OpenMRS community is approximately 2,000 members strong as of late 2011. This year, it called for applications for a total of 20 potential GSoC projects, its largest ever since the programme started in 2007. The past year is also noteworthy because of the number of endorsements OpenMRS won from various governments and the international community. OpenMRS has weathered the passage of time well, and stands strong as a mature and capable organisation. It embodies the values of both the open source community and voluntarism. The organisation's efforts have brought benefits to millions the world over. One can only hope that the world will learn from the difference OpenMRS has made in many disaster-ravaged nations, and support it in its bid to provide better healthcare for all. 

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The author is an active OpenMRS core contributor. He is a former GSoC 2011 student and also a mentor for GSoC 2012. He is also featured in the Google Open Source blog for his active post-GSoC contributions to the community; <http://google-opensource.blogspot.in/2011/12/students-write-code-and-save-lives-with.html>.

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